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Ray Blue

Saxophonist and jazz educator Ray Blue has performed with a diverse group of ensembles, including the Harlem Blues & Jazz Band, the Sun Ra Arkestra, and the Ray Charles touring company. He is- the founder of Cross-Cultural Connection Inc., promoting jazz culture and community engagement.

Ray was interviewed via Zoom on June 23, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Ray Blue with me this afternoon, connecting from Peekskill to Clinton, New York. Welcome, Ray.

RB: Thank you. Thank you very much, Monk, it's a pleasure to be here.

MR: I remember fondly your visit to Hamilton and I've been recently listening to some of your recordings and I want to say I very much dig your sound.

RB: Well thank you. Thank you very much.

MR: One thing I like is the — believe it or not it reminded me a little bit of Whitney Houston when you take a long tone and you play it straight as an arrow and then you add some vibrato near the end.

RB: Okay.

MR: I like that.

RB: Yeah.

MR: How did you fashion your sound when you were a young man? Did you have some mentors or was it mostly just listening to recordings?

RB: It was mostly listening but fortunately when you say a young man, I'm thinking back to high school, because that's when I started to play in the combo, you know, playing out. But the idea that was taught, the concept that was taught was that it was important to finish a note. And I was told to listen to how certain people finish their notes. It may be — you don't play vibrato all the way through, you use it to put a tasty inflection on the end. That's what was described to me.

MR: That's a great concept. And I'm not sure that I could do better with that with my own students, on how to end a note. Sometimes I tell them to end a long note with a little exclamation point or an accent or something. It sort of justifies playing a long note, or something like that.

RB: Yeah. Yeah. How you finish determines how the beginning of the note actually comes across, and then how the next note will impact the listener.

MR: I read that while you were playing in the school jazz band that you were also getting — you were also in an R & B group?

RB: Yes. Yeah.

MR: Do you remember learning — how did you learn your parts?

RB: From records. From records, all that was learned from records you know. Junior Walker and the All-Stars — who else were we doing — we did, well at that time Mercy, Mercy came out, the Cannonball Adderley group came out. We did the Motown stuff. I listened to the parts you know. I knew the melodies and you would listen to them, you knew the rhythms, how the rhythm section worked, and you just learned those things. You could sing all the parts. You know?

MR: You can't beat that. That's the best ear training.

RB: Yeah, it is. I think so.

MR: This might sound like an odd question but at that time, when you were learning those parts, did you have a sense of the lines and the notes you were playing, how it related to the key that the song was in?

RB: Well that was before I had any understanding of theory, or much understanding of theory. It fit. It fit. It fit within — I could hear the chords, I could hear the chords and then I could hear how the notes of the lines I was playing fit inside the chords. I could hear if there was too much dissonance or it if I felt it was a wrong note, it didn't fit you know. But there was always a blend to hear. The lines and the harmonies and the melodies.

MR: Was there another horn player to work into the mix?

RB: At that time no. No. I was the only horn player in the group at that time.

MR: Ah. So yeah, give it to Ray, he'll do a solo here.

RB: Yeah. That's how it went.

MR: Do you remember your first paying gig and what you made?

RB: Yes I do remember. One of our strong supporters, an English teacher, Mr. John Sullivan, he ran the night school downstairs in the high school, and he had us come to play for his group. Now we only knew three tunes, starting out. And yeah, we got paid $15 — I think or no, was it six bucks apiece? Yeah, because they took up a collection. Yeah.

MR: You beat me by two dollars. Same situation, like in the high school. That's great. What was the name of this band?

RB: The Soul Sextet. Yeah.

MR: Well jumping ahead a little bit, apparently you heard "Kind of Blue" played for you by a seventh grade teacher and that was it. Did you— what made the biggest impression on you?

RB: Oh, the biggest impression of that. It grabbed me, Monk. He turned the music on and I listened and what was there — well the first tune was "So What" on the record, was "So What." And the introduction and the bass, the you know, the free bass line that was there

then into the melody and it just — Jimmy Cobb's on the cymbal. And it was on man. And yeah. That's what grabbed me. And there's no other explanation.

MR: When you heard Cannonball followed by Coltrane, were you at the point — this is seventh grade now — can you recall a preference or distinguishing one from the other?

RB: I didn't have a preference, however, my ear gravitated more to the tenor, the tenor sound. And actually yeah, yeah. I really got through it — no, no they were both — I was in junior high when I was listening to both of them. Because what I did was I had the opportunity to join the Columbia Record Club. You know, ten albums for 99 cents and then they send you a new one each month and then you take it or not. But records that I bought I got "Kind of Blue" I got one of them by Stan Getz "Dear Old Stockholm," Cannonball Adderley and Coltrane, it was "Grand Central," [scats] no that's the bridge, but and then my high school, one of my high school music teachers gave me a copy of "Giant Steps," the album. Yeah. But the distinction, the tenor sound, I gravitated more towards the tenor. I still loved the alto sound. Cannon had it. He spoke, the way he spoke was just amazing.

MR: Yeah. I'm a huge fan as well. And he had that tone that sort of leapt off the record.

RB: Yeah he did. His tone, his sound would lift you. You know it would lift you off — if you were standing it lifted you off your feet, if you were sitting it lifted you off your chair. It was just amazing. For me, I could hear heaven in that sound. Yeah. It's amazing.

MR: At what point did you get the notion or the possibility that you could make music your career or your destination. Because I see that you received a bachelor's and a master's in sociology, and here you are now as a professional musician. Did you have a conflict in your head about where you were going to go?

RB: Somewhat. Well not where I was going to end up, but how I get here. Here's how it went: I was offered music scholarships out of high school. But there was something — I didn't take them because there was other things I wanted to learn you know. And I said — and that's how I you know, that's how I thought about it. So yeah, so I studied soc and psych and then grad school I went into clinical social work. And when I got to grad school that's when I actually really started to bear down and started studying saxophone more. Because like yeah, that was it. And that's how that went.

MR: Now when I read that I got this flashback to I was fortunate to interview Phil Woods and he said, well a jazz career, let me put it this way, if you're trying to decide between a career as a brain surgeon or a jazz tenor man — he literally said 'tenor man' — he goes be the brain surgeon.

RB: Yeah. That's what some people would say. I know people that said he gave up music to make a living. You know? But you know one of the things my mentor in grad school, and I believe all the things we learn in life are transferrable to any situation you know. She

told me, she said, "Look you can do anything you want to do, as long as you can justify it." And I applied that, I knew what I wanted to do and then I knew I didn't take the traditional route by going to music school etcetera, studying music. But I knew this is what I was going to do. And so I began studying and I was at the University of Iowa and then I came back to New York and started hanging out and got with musicians, started studying and practicing a lot and started getting with different bands. And that's — it was just a matter of time before I was going to shift from what I was doing as a clinical social worker into music full time.

MR: So you were helping to pay your bills by doing what you had studied while you were transitioning into —

RB: Yeah. Well I still loved the work. See that was the thing. I had a passion for what I was doing there too. And I feel blessed in that manner. There are two aspects of work that I chose that I have a passion for. And I've been able to use both in different instances. I created some music therapy work and working with young people around music, and so that's been a real pleasure too. So making these strides and doing the things I needed to do to get my skill level up, get my jazz education, music educational piece together, I did all that stuff. I'm still learning man, and I love it, I love it. You know the more I'm learning there's more I'm seeing that I want to learn more of. You know? And I'm in a network in a circle playing with a lot of great musicians, really good people, and I'm happy.

MR: Can't do better than that.

RB: No I don't think so.

MR: I understand you spent a good deal of time in Europe, in fact in reading about you I believe it said you heard "Kind of Blue" in seventh grade and then you knew you wanted to go to Europe to play jazz?

RB: Yeah.

MR: So why? Why did you at that early age have this idea that Europe was going to be significant?

RB: One of the records I got from the Columbia Record Club was "Miles Davis in Europe." And you know I played it on my little hi-fi and you could hear how the music and the audience, the musicians and the audience just came together. They were somewhere in France because I remember the announcement was in French. And I just had that dream. That's what I want to do. Yeah. And I was twelve. That's what I wanted to do and I didn't know how I was going to get it done but that was the goal, the dream. And so I moved over there in 2000. I made an exploratory trip over in the fall of 1999, and then I made another trip over in the spring of 2000. And I had some gigs over there anyway, I was working with another band and we were — I was working with the Spirit of Life

Ensemble at the time too, and we were doing things, mostly in France. But I was there, I went to Germany and Switzerland and I met different people and I was mapping out a plan. And I was back I think maybe a week and I got a phone call and I was invited to come and play some festivals with some folks in Switzerland in September. So that was in, I believe it was in May, end of May beginning of June I got the call. And the dates went in the book and that was it. So I left on September 20th, 2000. I had a saxophone, a suitcase and the promise of three gigs. And that was it man.

MR: Oh, that's — I salute you.

RB: Yeah and from that I made my way. That was it man. I figured out how I was going to do it and that was it.

MR: I wonder if you ran into Alvin Queen over in Switzerland.

RB: Oh sure. But Alvin I had met some years earlier. One of my dearest friends and mentors Dr. Jesse Johnson I met Alvin through him. And Dr. Johnson gave me my first Mark VI back in — it's a 1957 — yeah, my Mark VI. He said, "Look man, it's time for me to pass this on because you're going to take this further than I can go with it anymore. And I still have it. And her name is "Baby." Yeah. But I met him through — I met Alvin through Dr. Johnson, I met Art Davis, the great bassist Art Davis, I met Stanley Cowell through him. Yeah.

MR: I'm not sure how to phrase this question but due to your study in psychology do you think that you play to the audience or to an audience member more than other musicians?

RB: More than? I don't know about more than.

MR: I guess what I'm picturing is some musicians you see them and they're on the stage and their eyes are closed and I get the impression that they are playing totally for themselves, not that it's — this is not a judgmental thing but then I see other musicians who seem to be a little more aware of their surroundings and who they're playing for.

RB: Well yeah, well I learned this too. We're not playing really for ourselves, we're playing for a listener and we're communicating. Music is the language that we're communicating with one another. There's a connection between the audience and the artist. And I feel that it's important to connect with that. That's an important part of what fuels what comes out. You know? It's important. So that's how I view it. You know that's how I view it. Yeah we practice a lot and these different things that we want to do as musicians and feel with the camaraderie on stage but the ultimate part is that we're all communicating with one another to communicate with our listener.

MR: I remember seeing Cannonball, I think I saw him live about three times. And that was a big part of what he did is that even before he played he had a welcoming delivery to the audience. He made you want to listen harder and sometimes gave you a little information about the tunes and so forth that I tried to remember as a worthwhile thing to do.

RB: Yeah. He was like a preacher you know or a very astute professor. Yeah. What he had to say, and his voice, was one that he spoke so well. And it was also a part of his presentation, the music and all. You know? I like to — I've adopted some of that yeah. Sharing some information, a little storytelling, reflecting on some things that are going on on stage whether it's between us and the audience, sure man, that's connecting with an audience man is so important I believe. Some folks they just get up and start playing and play great every day and the audience connects with them. My thing is to connect from a personal, with some verbiage as well.

MR: I was happy to see that you recorded [scats]

RB: Yeah.

MR: "Sweet Emma."

RB: Yes, "Sweet Emma." It was, yeah, that's another great tune and there's a story behind it that's great as well, because Emma was one of those persons who, a woman in the man's world who made her presence, it was something else. And she not only is a great player but a dynamic personality. That song was written about her. You know? And so yeah, it had a strong sassy swing thing to it, and Nat [Adderley] did a great job.

MR: He did. This may not seem like a big deal but you recorded "Everything Happens to Me." And the whole first statement of the melody it's just you and the drums. Am I correct?

RB: Yes.

MR: To me that is such a terrific thing to do and not many people if they even think of doing it they wouldn't do it anyway. And I think it's worth noting from an arranger's standpoint that within a quartet you've got all these possibilities of combinations. So I just wanted to say I'm glad you did it.

RB: Well thank you. Thank you. It's one of those things that happened. You know we plan for things and this was just one that we said you know, let's try this. I want to try this. So we did it. And Steve Johns, who was on the drum track on that, Steve is an amazing cat to work with in the studio you know. His studio skills are second to none, really. He's a great cat playing live with but in the studio his experience and knowledge and the way he connects, I keep using that word but it's really a relevant term. The way he connects with me, or the person that's doing the lead, he's right there. He's right there. You know? And he's sensitive to each breath I take. He feels the emotion, where it's leading. He speaks very well and supports — he's a great musician you know.

MR: Yes and in the studio, it's interesting you mention that because sometimes we can be separated, the drummer might be in a booth or something so they really have to be tuned in from their ears.

RB: In that particular case he was in the room next to me and we could see one another.

MR: Uh huh.

RB: Yeah. And that worked too so we — so that's the deal. That's how that came about.

MR: What's the average time — I don't know if you can estimate this but on your own recordings how much studio time do you usually get?

RB: Well I would start out with probably a ten hour block. And then work it from there. Some folks go in and then they say all right I'm going to record all the tracks. The way I prefer to do it is that we'll do as many tracks as it feels good with. You know? If the energy dissipates or something and it's time to stop then we stop and then come back. Yeah. That's it. I'll start with ten hours and then we have time to go over a couple of things if we feel like it you know, at the end you do a listening and you say yeah well I'd like to do that a little differently and we'll do it again, do a track again. But when it's there you hear it and you know it and then you can move on to the next.

MR: When it comes time to mix are the other members around or do you find it better to have as few people as possible in on that process?

RB: No, no, I'm not having any other cats. Everybody hears their own.

MR: Everybody wants to push up their fader.

RB: You know yeah. It's the engineer, producer and myself. That's enough. Yeah. Funny. You know how that goes.

MR: No one ever says hey I think I'm a little too loud.

RB: Yeah. On this most recent recording I called in Bobby Sanabria to lay some tracks. And Bobby is another phenomenal one. Wow. Wow. And then he'd come in, I gave him, I sent him the music ahead of time and he came in with his notes and the markings on the pages and then he goes in and he made his track. He came in and listened and said hmmm, and he could pinpoint certain things, and go back and bam, he'll hit it and it's done. And then he said all right now I hear this to go in and he'll have another percussive instrument. Etcetera. And then when we did the final listen before he leaves, you know, I love you Bobby, but we have to do it, "Yeah okay Bobby, sure Bobby, yeah Bobby." "Add a little of this," "Okay Bobby." But he's right and so it makes sense because you know, you fine tune. But what he does is he's hearing these things and they're really fine points, usable points. And so when it came time to start the mixing, bam, it was in there and all we had to do was fine tune it. You know? The "yeah-yeah" came because Bobby had so much energy. He goes on and on because he's a perfectionist and he hears everything. You know he hears how it works with the drummer, where the accent is falling with the bass player, you know, on which beat of the measure or which subdivision part of the measure, where the piano player is rhythmically playing so that what he's doing, it works to enhance. Because that's his job. You know. So yeah, that was great working with him as well.

MR: All right. Let's talk about the blues. Do you have a definition of your own, maybe I want to borrow it. In about a week I'm doing a little presentation about the blues for some group and I often struggle with a succinct but accurate definition of the blues.

RB: A succinct and accurate definition of the blues.

MR: Or just Ray Blue's definition.

RB: Yeah I think that's all I could give you.

MR: I'll take the pressure off.

RB: Yeah. That's nice of you. The blues, it's — the blues is it's an expression of your life experience. And that's really as simple as I could put it. It's an expression. Now you could put that in any genre or whatever, but since we're talking about blues it's an expression of your life experience. And it can pinpoint the joy, the humility, or even some sadness that you may be experiencing or have experienced that's made a mark on you, it touches — it reflects your spirit in the purest sense. It really does. Because all of the — because for me I find the blues in all this stuff you know, and playing jazz and playing American music I can hear and find the blues in all of it, there's an element of it. And as a player it works, it works in the different genres of American music. It's in there where you find that flat third or that raised fourth or flatted fifth, where and how it's placed you know, that's where we speak.

MR: Well said. I wanted to share something I read recently and this is the first opportunity I've had to share it. This is from Kurt Vonnegut from his last book, *A Man Without a Country* and I'm only slightly paraphrasing here. Kurt said "I really like Strauss and Mozart and all that, but the priceless gift that African-Americans gave the whole world was a gift so great that it is now almost the only reason many foreigners still like us. All pop music today: jazz, swing, bebop, Elvis Presley, the Beatles, the Stones, rock & roll, hip-hop and on and on is derived from the blues."

RB: Yeah. It's the American experience. The blues is the American experience. Now blues didn't originate in America. Blues came over from Africa. Okay? I don't know if you've had the opportunity or experience to hear some of the, you know, some of the music in Africa that depicts that sound, but it's there man. I've heard it. And the way it developed here is uniqueness. That's our culture you know. That's American culture. And I agree with what he said, this is something that has permeated and touched the rest of the world and I believe that despite what others say or think I believe that the rest of the world has a great appreciation for us because of the blues. It's touched everybody because they can't play what they call jazz without touching the blues either, and this is a music that is just — we've shared it with the world. You know? And I agree, it's one of the reasons, it gives them a reason to like us. Yeah. Everywhere I go, anywhere I go, and this has been in any country that I've been in we're treated differently, we're treated respectfully

because we play the music. Okay? I think that's just something to think about. We are, I don't know if we're the only country, modern country, who doesn't have a Ministry of Culture. Okay? All these Western European countries have a Ministry of Culture where artists are supported. You know? It's built into their culture. Ours is built-in differently. You know? There's a whole — I don't know — do you understand what I'm saying? They have a Ministry of Culture it's part of the government system. So if an artist — that's how important our culture is in that if you're having hard times earning the money you can get government support because you're an artist, to help sustain you to continue to do what you do, because you contribute something that's valuable. You know? We have to go about it another way here in America. We have to find support from other places. You know? And we have to look for them. It's not offered to us because we're artists. We have to find it then make application for it, da-da-da-da-da. We have to find supporters and entrepreneurs and philanthropists to help us through. It's not like that in a lot of other places. And I equate that to how they respect the necessity for art within the culture.

MR: Jazz in particular in the last thirty or so years has been elevated, rightfully so, in academia and Jazz at Lincoln Center, on and on. It doesn't seem to translate to a place in the marketplace. It's a bit of a conundrum it seems like.

RB: Um hum. Yeah. It is, however, we find a way to make it work. You know? There's one thing that's said about the human condition and that is people will get used to anything. All right? So our situation, okay it's what it is. I'm used to it and here's what I do to make it work for me, to continue to do what I do. That's how I look at it. It's the condition and I have to adapt to the condition. Otherwise I don't exist. And I'm not having that. You know? So yeah, so we find way to make things work. I created a not-for-profit organization, a 501(c)3. And we don't get a lot of — we don't apply for a lot of grants. We've been in operation for sixteen years or so. We run our own festival etcetera. The people support it. The people support the music. We get donations, some grants, but it's the people who support our organization and we are able to teach, we go out and we do workshops and clinics, master classes. We have an intergenerational ensemble. We have our own annual jazz festival, we have a weekly jazz series every Saturday throughout the summer and into the fall, and the people support it.

MR: This is your Cross-Cultural Connection, Inc. is that correct?

RB: Yes it is. Yes.

MR: Was there a moment you remember that set you on this path?

RB: You know when I was in graduate school I thought about how do I find grants for different things. And — because there's different kinds of programming I was thinking about wanting to do and then it came to a point I was invited to play at the North Sea Jazz

Festival in Cape Town. And being there, while there the organizers asked me to be one of the clinicians, a clinician to do a workshop. Hotep Galeta, the pianist, the great South African pianist, he and I did a workshop for township students in Cape Town. And from that point it was amazing, he was amazing, the feeling of the teaching and the response and the passion of the students for the music and how, what the music felt like for us, you know how we shared it. And from that point then I was asked to do a few other workshops while I was there. And that's how it started you know. So I'll say my whole piece started in South Africa. And what I wanted to do was to be able to bring people together so they had an opportunity to learn about one another by communicating with one another, not depending on what was in the newspaper or in a news broadcast. If you want to know how this person who lives in a township in South Africa, how they feel about certain things, ask them. You'll have an accurate answer. You know? So we brought people together through the music. And usually a part of my sessions is we would have dialogue with one another. You know? There were folks in the session who were also from South Africa who didn't know each other. They didn't know each other, but they began to talk to one another. And they found what they had in common or what they didn't have in common. You know? But what you learned you have the ability now to understand from a clearer perspective. You know? Yeah.

MR: We could use a good dose of that these days.

RB: And you know this. Absolutely. Yeah. But that's how it started. But then so whenever I would go, whenever I'd be on tour I'd make arrangements to do some teaching as well. I get a lot of enjoyment out of that and there's a lot of energy. And I started the organization in the States in Cedar Rapids, Iowa. I didn't start it in New York. I started it there, it's not far from the University of Iowa, but my kids were there. My two sons were there so I was making visits there so I said well let me set it up here. I was connected with a number of musicians and people in the community because when I'd go there I'd play, and we got registered there and being a small market there was only so much could be done, so I keep the registration there, we moved to New York, I set up here in New York so, and it's grown. It's grown immensely.

MR: Congratulations. Are your sons musical?

RB: They both played when they were very young but my oldest son, he's a football and track coach at the high school he graduated from. And his brother, who is a year and a half younger, he works for a Hospice organization.

MR: I was wondering if they or perhaps they might have a grandchild and, "Grandpa I want to be a professional musician." What do you think?

RB: What do I think? I would — well I would tell she or he that well you have to work hard and it has to be your decision, you know how you move towards that. You know? And

there's certain things that you're going to need to begin to learn to prepare yourself, to build your skills. And the first thing is you really love music. And let them take it from there. And I'll be supportive of whichever way they go.

MR: All right. Let me ask you about a few of the people you've performed with. Sun Ra?

RB: Um hum.

MR: What can you share with us about Sun Ra?

RB: Sunny was very interesting man. Sunny, it was an important time for me to meet Sunny and to — I actually auditioned to play with his group. It was a brief time but it was a time, it was amazing. He's a remarkable musician and a remarkable spirit. He has a concept that still lives today even though he's not here so there is something really really special and important about him. Playing in that band, well let's see, that's where I met John Gilmore as well and a quick story, I was the newbie in the band and I'm there waiting, because we rehearsed and we were reading charts and stuff. Okay. I didn't have any charts when we got to the gig. I'm the only one in the section and I'm looking around, the cats are ignoring me and I'm saying oh man, okay here we go. And Gilmore was watching me and finally he said, he said, "Look man, don't worry about it I got ya." I didn't know what that was supposed to mean. But the point of it was when the gig started there were no charts. So what I did was I listened, I paid very close attention to John, how he handled the situation. And yeah, you had to have your big ears on you know, because your role was to contribute and blend in a way that Sunny needed you to blend. Like he would just point to you and then you'd play. And I'm saying to myself what do I play? The guy said, "Play!" "Play what?" "Play, man." I said, "Okay." So yeah, so Marshall Allen, I was checking out Marshall and Sunny and a bunch of the other cats. And Gary Bartz was in that band at that time. He was there as well. And so the cats turned and looked at me with smiles I said I guess I'm doing the right thing man. So yeah. But that was an amazing experience. And Sunny had pulled me aside. And he was getting ready to do a video project. He says, "I got something for you, I want you to be a part of this." But it didn't happen. It didn't come to fruition because he had passed away. I didn't know he wasn't well at the time, but yeah that didn't happen. But that's how that was. Yeah.

MR: That's a great memory. And I had the pleasure of talking with Marshall Allen and he's quite a spirit. At the end he said something like I've been doing this for fifty years I'm still waiting to make some money.

RB: Yeah. Well money wasn't the center, play with Sunny. No. Forget that. But the music and the vibe and the people, the experience, that was it. And what I learned from him is that you know it's not all about money. It's just what are you going to learn from this? You know? How are you going to become better as a person, as a musician, just a better being

from being a part of this? That's what we have to look for. You know? That's what I got from Sun Ra's band.

MR: I see another strong personality here on your list, Bernard Purdie.

RB: Purdie. Yes. Yeah Purdie's a master man. You know it's as simple as that. He's strong, he's determined, he knows music and he knows what he's looking for in his sound and he knows how to make it work. When Purdie plays the band elevates. You know? There are a few drummers that I'll say yeah there are a few drummers that make that happen. You know? Purdie is one of them. You know you could have a band that's playing really well and then you stick Purdie in there, the band's going to elevate. The sound, the whole thing. Another person that I experienced that with is Bobby Durham you know. We were playing at Le Duc de Lombards in Paris and Bobby came to sit in, I said, "Yeah man, come on, sit in man." Actually I didn't know who he was and one of the guys in the band did and I said, "Well man I don't know who this cat is." He said, "You want him to sit in." I said well okay, I'll take your word. And Bobby got in and whoo. And the drummer I had, who was a great drummer, all right, his eyes was like holy smokes man, do I still have this gig? But yeah Bobby was another one of those special beings, you know a drummer who can just lift the band.

MR: That's a really special way to get to know somebody. Like I don't even know who this person is and all of a sudden they're lifting you up.

RB: Yeah. With my own music. And he was sitting in on the tunes. I called, you know I chose a tune that I knew he could, and woof — and the feelings, holy smokes.

MR: It's an interesting thing because it's hard to really define it. It's not like they're playing louder or they're playing more. It's just magic.

RB: Yeah. It's what they do, how they do, what they do. I'll put it like that. It's what they do, how they do it and with what they do. And it just woof — yeah. Sonny Sharrock taught me about that kind of thing. I studied with Sonny, a guitarist.

MR: Yes.

RB: Sonny taught me about it. I studied, I did some improv study with Sonny. And Sonny introduced me to five schools of jazz: Trane, Miles, Monk, Ornette, and — Monk, Miles, Trane, Ornette and who's the fifth one? Well those four.

MR: Okay.

RB: Yeah. And the thing was to get inside of that — you learn so much you know, you take compositions from any and all of them and you learn them and you analyze them. You learn the language that they're using, and how they're using harmonies you know. How they're presenting their lines, the melody lines and their phrases. You listen to the records and how they're interpreted on the recordings you know. Yeah. I still miss Sonny. I still miss Sonny.

MR: He wasn't on the scene all that long, was he?

RB: No, I would say he was kind of young when he passed, man. Sonny was only 52, 53 when he passed. You know he'd done work with Miles and with Herbie Mann and a bunch of others. Pharoah.

MR: If you're playing an uptempo standard that has a significant number of changes and they're going by fairly quickly, is it possible to tell us what is going on in your head as you're playing?

RB: Yeah. Slow it down. I want to slow it down. For me. I'll slow it down. Because you don't want to approach it in a frantic way. So in your head you're slowing it down. Now the changes are moving and the changes are moving along, well you look at the changes, you check out the changes and see how they connect you know, and where they connect. You know some are passing, some need to be pronounced, and hear how the rhythm is working and the time. And then so when you speak your phrases they'll fall in place, they'll fall in place. That's how I put it. I slow it down. Like you've got something that's moving really fast and then you want to kind of subdivide you know, you want to slow it down a little so that you hear and see everything you know. You're going to hear, your ears tell you a lot, your ears tell you a lot, and then what you've been practicing, studying, you know some stuff. You don't rely totally on your ears but you've got to know stuff. But what I do — my way of doing it is I'll slow it down and then even though the time didn't stop, doesn't slow down, I'll slow it down mentally so I can speak to what I'm hearing. Yeah. That's how I do it.

MR: Nice way to put it. And you said you've got to know some stuff.

RB: Yeah.

MR: What is paramount stuff for you?

RB: Well you've got to know, like for instance, all right like for instance when you have 2-5's, I don't focus on the 2. It's the 5's that I'll focus on. You know? Because the 2 is incorporated in the 5. You know? That's one of the things. The — okay the most important scale that we have is the chromatic scale. Right? You know because each thing moves a half step down, a half step up, make all the difference. Okay? The next two important scales are the whole tone scale — it's an even, it's an even and equal scale, six tones in each one, everything is equal. And then the diminished, which comes from the whole tone. You know two from each — it's minor thirds, so you have in each whole tone scale the two tones are a tri-tone apart. You know? And the dominant. Well you take a diminished chord and you lower any tone a half a step in a chromatic and you've got a dominant seventh. Now a dominant seventh is our most pivotal chord. All right? And what I mean by that is there are so many different combinations, you could play dominant, you could play minor, you could play diminished, you could play half-

diminished, you could play diminished whole tone. You know? Yeah. You put a flat nine or a sharp nine on there and you've got your diminished whole tone. You know so this is stuff you've got to know. Okay? And the most important thing is it's all connected. Nothing is disjointed. It all comes from and leads to what is central. So yeah, so that's some of the stuff that we want to know. Yeah. You want to know your basic, six basic jazz chords and your major, dominant, minor, half-diminished, diminished, and augmented. Then you'll add other combinations you know, your triads, major triads, minor triads, major sixth and minor sixth, etc. You know, and how they all work. You know how they work. How do we do that? Well we isolate and we practice, but we listen. You've got to listen to the music. And we can learn how they're used, how the language is used. You know to connect and have fun with it.

MR: I'm glad you ended with that, to have fun with it.

RB: I — yeah — I have fun with this stuff.

MR: Good.

RB: Excuse me. There aren't as many opportunities for musicians to go out to jam. There used to be a lot more. There's still some, but you've got to get out and play with cats. You know. Even now, you go places, you go play man and it's important. I'll finish a gig and then find out where cats are playing a little later, you know, and go and listen or just go sit in. And then yeah, you hear how cats are handling the language man. Yeah.

MR: Let me wrap up with asking you what it's been like to — you had a long tenure with the Harlem Blues & Jazz Band, and shared the stage with some older gentlemen. I wonder what that's been like?

RB: It's been wonderful you know. I came into that band as the baby. Doc [Vollmer] came to one of the sessions, the jam sessions at the union hall and that's where he heard me, and he liked what I was doing and he spoke with me, and he pulled me in as a back-up or a sub for Fred.

MR: Staton. Yes.

RB: Because Fred was, his health was starting to be more challenged, you know, and that was — and Joey Morant was there and Art Baron on trombone. Now Art had played with, in the Ellington band when Duke was still leading it, and he's got a lot of experience and stories and a great musician. Jackie [Williams], and Jackie on drums. The stories these cats had, and you learn man, it's all about learning. Zeke Mullins — Zeke was Hamp's piano player for what 20-some years? You know and Zeke, old Zeke man, they were really great guys. And at the time Ruth Brisbane was singing and I loved her voice, I loved her voice man and she —

MR: Yeah, she had that church Gospel combination with pig foot and a bottle of beer or something like that.

RB: A pig foot and a bottle of beer! Okay. You know it's all true, what you said. It is true. She had all of it. Yeah. The church, the pig foot, and the bottle of beer, she had it all. And she could bring it man. She could simply bring it. And she was a sweetheart. I really loved her. And when it was time for her to sing man, I'd lay back and just listen you know, and it inspired notes for me to play underneath her too, you know, the way she did it, it fit that tenor sound. Yeah. And that was wonderful. We did some tours, the tours that we did, when I was with them we were in Europe a few times, Denmark, Sweden. We had like a 12-day tour in Russia in December. You know something? It was colder in New York that year in December than it was in Russia at that time. Yeah. Yeah. It was colder here. But it was a great — we played, the venues were amazing. I mean concert halls, yeah. They had us in concert halls, flew us. Well Russia is huge anyway. Oh man, you know you fly for three or four hours, then you take an overnight train, and you're still in Russia. Those kind of things. Yeah, it was great. It was great.

MR: Yeah I give Dr. Vollmer a lot of credit for the audaciousness of sort of what he does in handling the logistics and all of that. There's a lot of passion there.

RB: Well Doc, you know Doc was part of the show as well because Doc made a point of informing the audience of the history and the importance of the development of the band and this sound and this music. You know? He made — his opening remarks were very powerful and very much needed. And the way he pulled people together, and the way he cared about people. Doc cares about people. You know? Doc would make sure cats had — he would make sure there were gigs because he said these musicians who made all this great music, they're not appreciated anymore. I have to find a way to keep them in the public eye because that's where they deserve to be, and that's how he created the band and he kept it going. Forty-some years. Actually — excuse me — he called on me to kind of help out with some bookings when we can, and we're going to be playing on the second of July in Peekskill as part of the Cross Cultural Connection Saturday night series. So we're going to be doing that, we're going to be at the New Rochelle Library in December, we booked that one. We were down in the Rocky Mountains, for the Monk Festival last year, we went down to North Carolina, we went down there. Yeah. Now that Zeke isn't with us anymore, Danny Mixon plays piano with us now, yeah. We also, oh yeah there were a couple of other trombone players too, Ron Wilkins, a phenomenal trombone player. Clarence Banks, he went down to Carolina with us. He's with the Basie band and he played with us as well. Yeah, it's been really nice. So we're keeping things going, Doc's keeping things going.

MR: Well I want to thank you for your time and for your significant contributions to the music. You've found a way to perform and sort of do public service and keep the music alive, and I appreciate it.

RB: Oh thank you, thank you very much. I'm enjoying every moment of it. I'm fortunate, Monk, I'm doing what I love to do. I can't see doing it any other way. People say oh you're lucky to be able to do it. Well it's a choice I made, and for anyone who does this it's a choice we make, as with yourself. You made choices that kept you involved in keeping the history, the music, all of this, the education, the passing on information, keeping all that alive and moving along. And here we are.

MR: Here we are. And I've quoted a few musicians today so I'm going to quote one more, and this is a quote from Ray Blue: "To be able to work at what you love and make it your life's work is a blessing."

RB: Very well said.

MR: Well said indeed.

RB: It is true.

MR: Okay.

RB: Thank you very much.

MR: Thank you.